



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 13

IOWA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Iowa's family courts and child-welfare system.

64

IOWA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 100
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 4, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

26 OF 99

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

01 NAMED COURT ACTORS · IOWA

A name appears below only after 3 or more independent families have named the same actor in Iowa. Submitter names, emails, and contact details are never published. Comments below are direct family reports — one per family — with all identifying information removed.

Cynthia Hucks

ATTORNEY (OPPOSING) · WAPELLO · 10 FAMILIES

"There is a lot to list but the two major take aways. 1. I paid her to file and argue a contempt of court for non visitation. She filed however she never scheduled a court date. 2. I have paid her nearly 15k and I honestly believe I would be far better off if I represented myself." JEFFERSON

"She helped me leave my abuser and fight for what was fair for my children. She is a busy attorney just like any good one, but her job is implacable!"

"She failed to provide me with court dates and tell me that i needed character affidavits in my daughter's custody case in 2010"

"She used manipulation tactics to get her way, lied to court, pressured me to resolve our case outside of court, and very rude!"

"Amazing lawyer, did everything I asked. She has helped me and so many other families"

"Produced illegal documents. Placed me in a room alone with her and my abuse."

"They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house" UNKNOWN

"Amazing. Derek lane is a narcissist and liar"

"Litigation harassment and abuse"

"She's one sided"

Public threshold rule: Names are grouped conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and location. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials collapse together. Close misspellings are not auto-merged without admin review. Only family-direct submissions count toward the public threshold.

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

IOWA AT A GLANCE.

Across 64 Iowa families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 100 64 of 64 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$288,250 median across 20 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 57.8% 37.5% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 64	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.6	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 64 of 64	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 26

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Iowa families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

03 THE COST OF IOWA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	40	\$7,000	\$32,880	\$1,315,200
Lost Wages	34	\$15,000	\$105,906	\$3,600,800
Other Court Fees	20	\$200	\$10,320	\$206,400
Therapy / Evaluations	27	\$2,500	\$7,097	\$191,620
Reunification Services	14	\$0	\$1,036	\$14,500
GAL Fees	21	\$0	\$3,371	\$70,800
Asset Loss ¹	30	\$17,500	—	—
Median Family Burden (20 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$288,250	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$17,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		44	3.7 yrs
Total across all families		1,831	152.6 yrs

04 WHO IS REPORTING · IOWA

Most families documenting in Iowa are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		25	39%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		12	19%
Case closed: within last 2 years		10	16%
Not provided		10	16%
Not in court but still affected		5	8%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		34	53%
Family Court Only		14	22%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		10	16%
Unknown		6	9%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		21	33%
6 months – 1 year		12	19%
5 – 10 years		11	17%
Over 10 years		5	8%
3 – 5 years		4	6%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		21	33%
Visitation Only		10	16%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		10	16%
Full Custody		9	14%
Children in Foster Care		8	12%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Wapello		16	25%
Polk		5	8%
Benton		3	5%
Woodbury		3	5%
Marshall		3	5%
Dallas		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		18	28%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		11	17%
Other: (Short answer)		8	12%
Other		5	8%
High Conflict Divorce		5	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — IOWA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Iowa comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Punished an innocent, safe parent and ripped my children away unnecessarily. They destroyed my family and career.

— HEATHER

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The court system erased siblings from other children's life while letting the ex move in with his mom and legally kidnap the kids while other siblings wonder what happened as no contact came even though it was allowed. No evidence heard just a pay off.

— IOWA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM IOWA

They Stole our Lives for their financial Gain, destroyed out whole family major Trauma

— RENADA

Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to [...]

— LINDSAY

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

— NICOLE

Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

— KODY

They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

— CASSIE

The courts were allowed to violate every constitutional protected right of parent and children. Record everything, video footage, audio, document.

— DEREK

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Due to false allegations CPS has took one of our 4 children and refuses to give him back. We jumped through their hoops and was told it still was not good enough. The money can be replaced but we have lost all of my sons first moments in life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These people have created such havoc in our lives. My children have been ripped away from us for false drug test results that came from the lab that are inaccurate and have kept my children from us without increasing visitation because I won't do what they want me to do. I have asked [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged sexual assault. There is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want the girls to come home but they won't even [...]

— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

The system has failed us and ripped us limb from limb

— JEANANE

Total devastation. Irreversible trauma and emotional damage

— ERICA

Ruined my children's quality of life. We lost precious years and time we will never gain back!

— PATRICIA

The family court process enabled my abuser to present as the victim while extensive, documented evidence of domestic violence, coercive control, community defamation, and severe trauma to me and my children went unaddressed. The result has been psychological disability, loss of [...]

— EMILLY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Alienated me from my kids for at least a decade.

— DAVID

She helped my children and I even tho we had barely any money and I'm thankful with her for life!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has torn my life apart with no end in sight. Now they want to send my daughter to another state for treatment.

— LONI

Our family has been destroyed by DHS, Foster Care, Judicial system, Familes First, 4 Oaks, it has caused so much pain & heartache. Now I have custody of my oldest granddaughter, but the youngest is still with the Bio father of my oldest granddaughter.

— MELISSA

What the attorney and mother has done to my son, by keeping his children from him and me the grandma is so uncalled for. He is such a good father to his children but the mom does not know how to co parent and follow custody orders.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has made me question myself as a parent, and I have now developed severe depression and anxiety.

— GENESIS

They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house

— COURTNEY

They didn't just take my children—they fractured our sense of safety, turned our home into a case file, and left a family grieving each other while still alive.

— DESTINY

It was hell that still has never end. Not amount of time can be given back and it has traumatized me and my children and had an effect on my youngest child's custody. Not being allowed to see my youngest child. And not being allowed to seek safety from my ex to give guardian ship [...]

— LOIS

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



As tore us apart all they wanna do is bridge orders for my kids playing games with me not ratification at all it's a game to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went from being the primary, daily presence in my children's lives to being reduced to visitation through a process that was opaque, procedurally unfair, and impossible to challenge. Now I have court-ordered parenting time that is intentionally withheld for months at a time [...]

— NATE

DHS refused to encourage reunification. Put my daughter in teachers home instead of family. My daughter has been manipulated against me. I can't concentrate at work, depression, PTSD, anxiety. This has destroyed our family!!

— MICHELLE

It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

— EMILY AND IAN

Family fraud court has annihilated my family, my financial security, my physical, mental and even my dental health. Family court has triggered my C-PTSD so badly that I am unable to work, unable to trust others, unable to be happy, unable to relate to anyone that is not mourning [...]

— JODI

Family court is not about justice. It's about how much justice you can afford.

— DION

Tore my family apart, hard to get a job,

— RONDA

The courts today care more about protecting workers right, than that of parents. Children are not just a bonus check there our future, why would we want to ruin there childhood with lies and coaching.

— PAULA

I had no money and she still helped. Also Derek lane is a narcissist.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Did everything I asked and even more, an amazing lawyer

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Judge Milani's risked my 1 year old's safety by giving a sex offender unsupervised access to her. 1 year old, with no way to protect herself. Is that what's in the best interest of the child?

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cynthia Hucks ruined my life. The only thing I got to keep in my divorce was my kids. But there were stipulations with that also. The ex could take the kids if he felt he needed to. She is a vile person and only thinks of what she can gain.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They took a family who loved each other and tore them apart.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court's six-year custody battle has ignored evidence, alienated your son, and cost your family milestones

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

HHS removed my son without a hearing based on his grandmother's lies on an affidavit without even speaking to me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cynthia completely destroyed my son's up bringing along with both of our mental health and he will carry that for the rest of his life. My son and I both have PTSD stemming from this, it is all documented.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My oldest daughter has now been hospitalized in a psych ward due to her step mom as of january this year I had hearing in feb and proved abuse in the home but the courts said they did no wrong my youngest child stated this last week she wanted to kill herself at her dad's cause [...]

— AMBER

It has ruined my life

— HEATHER

47 Iowa parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — IOWA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Iowa families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Punished an innocent, safe parent and ripped my children away unnecessarily. They destroyed my family and career.

— HEATHER

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— LINDSAY

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

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They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The courts were allowed to violate every constitutional protected right of parent and children. Record everything, video footage, audio, document.

— DEREK

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These people have created such havoc in our lives. Mychildren have been ripped away us for false drug test results that came from the lab that are inaccurate and have kept my children from us without increasing visitation because I won't do what they want me to do. I habe asked for almost a year to get the results from the lab that does the testing and nobody would help me. I finally received the lab date package and mow have proof that their tests are faulty and not accurate ... my first attorney flat out said my office will mot be fighting these results and we will not be requesting anything from the lab. If he would have done what I requested a year ago they would have had nothing to use to take my children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged alleged sexual assault. there is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want a girls to come home but they won't even let me see him has been six months. I have no contact order and through DHS sent Christmas presents and got thrown in jail and had to pay \$8800 to get out +4000 for breaking restraining order or no contact order.

— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— PATRICIA

The family court process enabled my abuser to present as the victim while extensive, documented evidence of domestic violence, coercive control, community defamation, and severe trauma to me and my children went unaddressed. The result has been psychological disability, loss of my role as primary caregiver, separation from my family, and the destruction of my career, home, and financial stability.

— EMILLY

Alienated me from my kids for at least a decade.

— DAVID

She helped my children and I even tho we had barely any money and I'm thankful with her for life!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— LOIS

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— NATE

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It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

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— JODI

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— DION

Tore my family apart, hard to get a job,

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My oldest daughter has now been hospitalized in a psych ward due to her step mom as of january this year I had hearing in feb and proved abuse in the home but the courts said they did no wrong my youngest child stated this last week she wanted to kill herself at her dad's cause she isn't loved....im tryung to contact a lawyer and get things changed but will see

— AMBER

It has ruined my life

— HEATHER

Caused severe P.T.S.D. as well as put a major damper on my personal relationship with my daughters as well as my current relationship & my social life due to D.H.H.S. coming to my home weekly.

— BRIAN

Left out an older child by friends of the court and let exes mom get guardianship where ex lived... because money matters more than saftey when everyone in the circle knows eachothers secrets"

— AMBER

Torn out whole family apart

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

47 full approved Iowa comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Iowa report comes from Iowa respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Iowa — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 64 Iowa families reporting here are not the universe of Iowa families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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